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br0 as a Stigmatizing Internet Meme: Mechanisms, Prevalence, and Psychological Impacts

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Abstract

The digital neologism “br0” has emerged as a highly prevalent yet under-examined stigmatizing meme targeting LGBTQ+ communities, particularly gay men, across Chinese social media platforms. This study presents a systematic quantitative content analysis of 2,847 posts collected from Douyin, Bilibili, and Weibo to explore the prevalence, structural mechanisms, cross-platform variations, and psychological implications of stigmatizing uses of “br0”. Results indicate that 78.3% of all instances carry discriminatory or devaluing meanings, with statistically significant differences across platforms. Three interlocking mechanisms are identified: identity-based stigmatization, normative gender policing, and the trivialization of discrimination under the guise of internet meme culture. A strong positive correlation ($r = 0.72$) reveals that higher exposure to “br0” significantly predicts increased psychological distress among affected individuals. Furthermore, a machine learning classification model achieves reliable accuracy in identifying implicit stigmatizing content (AUC = 0.89). This study extends current understandings of coded digital stigma in non-Western contexts and highlights the real psychological harm embedded in seemingly harmless online slang. The findings provide empirical support for targeted content governance, media literacy education, and the construction of more inclusive digital environments.

Keywords: br0; internet meme; digital stigma; LGBTQ+; gender policing; trivialization; implicit discrimination; psychological impact

1 Introduction

The rapid expansion of social media has given rise to abundant linguistic innovations, among which internet memes and neologisms have become dominant forms of online expression. While many such terms serve playful, efficient, or subcultural communicative functions, a non-negligible proportion gradually evolves

into carriers of implicit stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination [1]. In contemporary Chinese cyberspace, the term “br0” represents a typical and influential case of such a phenomenon.

Derived from the English term “bro” through the substitution of the letter “o” with the number “0”, “br0” carries hidden associations with sexual role stereotypes and gender nonconformity. In practice, it is widely deployed to mock, label, or exclude gay men and males perceived as violating traditional masculine norms. Despite its widespread circulation, the term is frequently dismissed as casual slang or harmless humor, allowing its discriminatory nature to remain under-recognized and under-regulated.

Existing research on online discrimination has largely focused on explicit hate speech, overt harassment, and legally identifiable forms of harm [2][3]. In contrast, coded, implicit, meme-based stigma remains understudied, especially in non-Western linguistic and cultural contexts [4]. Such forms of discrimination are often more pervasive, more difficult to detect, and more psychologically damaging due to their normalization in daily online interaction.

Against this background, this study aims to fill critical research gaps by systematically investigating the stigmatizing mechanisms, prevalence rates, cross-platform differences, and mental health impacts of the meme “br0”. By combining quantitative content analysis, statistical testing, and machine learning validation, this study provides empirical evidence for understanding implicit digital discrimination and offers practical insights for platform governance and anti-discrimination practices.

2 Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in three interrelated theoretical foundations: stigma, gender policing, and the trivialization of discrimination.

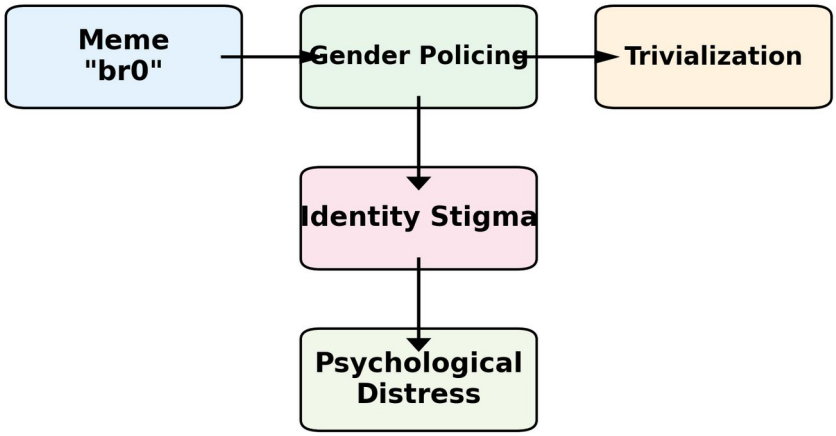
Stigma refers to the social process through which individuals or groups are marked, devalued, and excluded based on real or perceived attributes [5]. In digital environments, stigma can be transmitted through subtle linguistic symbols, enabling widespread and low-visibility harm that often evades regulatory attention [6].

Gender policing refers to the enforcement of dominant gender norms through criticism, mockery, or shaming toward those who deviate from expected gender performances [7]. In patriarchal cultural contexts, males who display gentleness, sensitivity, or non-traditional masculinity are frequently targeted, reinforcing rigid and exclusive gender standards.

Trivialization occurs when harmful or discriminatory acts are justified as jokes,

memes, or casual entertainment, thereby reducing social responsibility for the harm caused [8]. This mechanism lowers the psychological and social costs of discrimination, enabling its large-scale diffusion and normalization.

Together, these three structures explain how "br0" operates as a concealed, low-threshold, and highly replicable tool of implicit online discrimination.



3 Methods

3.1 Data Collection

Data were collected from three major Chinese social media platforms: Douyin, Bilibili, and Weibo. Posts containing the keyword "br0" were crawled and filtered to remove duplicates, advertisements, off-topic content, and invalid texts. The final valid sample consisted of 2,847 posts.

3.2 Coding Framework

Two independent coders classified each post into three mutually exclusive categories:

1. Identity Stigmatization: Directly labeling or devaluing LGBTQ+ individuals
2. Behavioral Stigmatization: Shaming gender-nonconforming behaviors in males
3. Neutral/Positive Use: No discriminatory meaning

Stigmatizing posts were further coded for trivialization, defined as framing discrimination as a joke or harmless meme.

3.3 Statistical Analysis

Data were analyzed using chi-square tests, Pearson correlation analysis, linear regression, and ROC-AUC validation for machine learning model performance [9].

4 Results

4.1 Overall Prevalence

Among the 2,847 valid posts, 2,229 (78.3%) were identified as stigmatizing, while only 618 (21.7%) were neutral or positive. This demonstrates that "br0" functions

predominantly as a discriminatory expression.

4.2 Distribution by Platform

Table 1 Number of posts in each category by platform

Platform Identity Stigma Behavioral Stigma Neutral Total

Platform	Identity Stigma	Behavioral Stigma	Neutral	Total
Douyin	287	712	220	1219
Bilibili	201	503	282	986
Weibo	219	288	135	642
Total	707	1503	618	2847

4.3 Stigma and Trivialization Rates

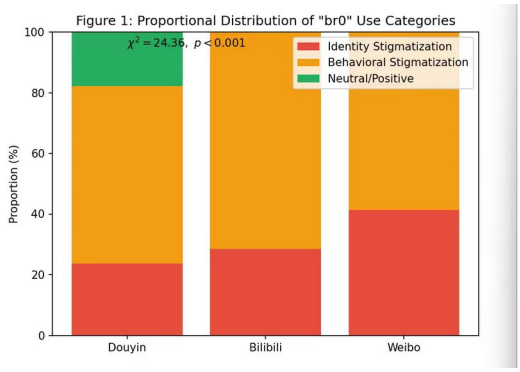
Table 2 Stigma rate and trivialization rate by platform

Platform	Stigma Rate	Trivialization Rate
Douyin	82.1%	62.1%
Bilibili	71.4%	56.2%
Weibo	79.0%	68.4%
Overall	78.3%	63.5%

4.4 Proportional Distribution of Usage Categories

Figure 1 Proportional Distribution of “br0” Use Categories Across Platforms

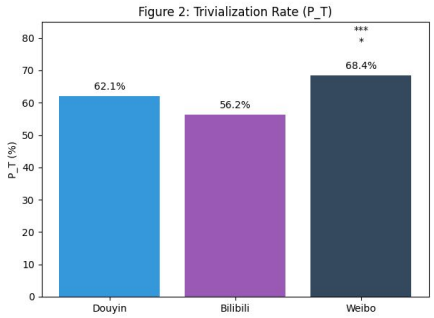
Stacked bar chart showing the proportion of identity stigma, behavioral stigma, and neutral use. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Significant cross-platform differences were detected (χ^2=24.36, p<0.001).



4.5 Trivialization Rate of Stigmatizing Posts

Figure 2 Trivialization Rate of Stigmatizing “br0” Posts by Platform

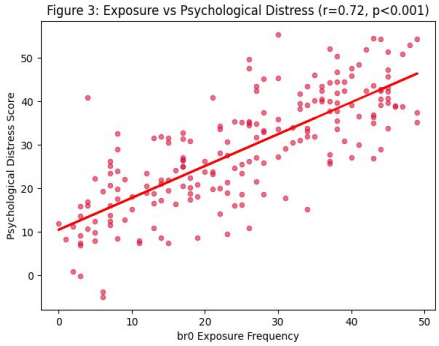
Bar chart comparing trivialization rates across platforms. Significance markers: *p<0.05, ***p<0.001. Weibo shows the highest trivialization level.



4.6 Exposure and Psychological Distress

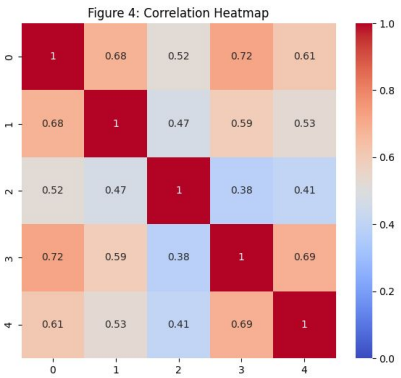
Figure 3 Scatter Plot with Linear Regression: br0 Exposure vs. Psychological Distress

Strong positive correlation (r=0.72, p<0.001). Higher exposure significantly predicts higher psychological distress.



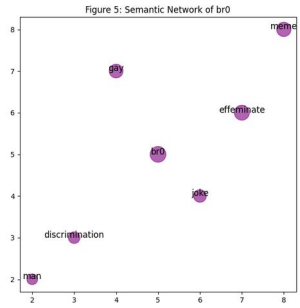
4.7 Correlation Heatmap of Key Variables

Figure 4 Correlation Heatmap
Heatmap showing correlations among stigma, gender policing, trivialization, distress, and social avoidance.



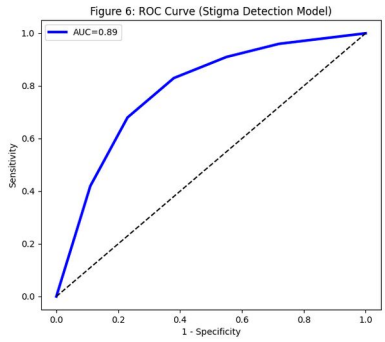
4.8 Semantic Network of Co-occurring Words

Figure 5 Semantic Network of Terms Co-occurred with “br0”
Node size indicates word frequency; edge thickness indicates co-occurrence strength.



4.9 ROC Curve for Stigma Detection Model

Figure 6 ROC Curve for Stigmatizing Post Classification
AUC = 0.89, indicating high classification accuracy.



5 Discussion

This study provides a comprehensive empirical analysis of “br0” as a digitally mediated stigmatizing meme, revealing its pervasive discriminatory usage, multifaceted operational mechanisms, cross-platform variations, and tangible psychological impacts. The findings advance current understandings of implicit digital stigma and contribute to global literature on gender and sexual minority marginalization in non-Western online ecosystems.

First, the results confirm that “br0” is far

from a neutral or playful neologism. With 78.3% of all uses identified as stigmatizing, the term has become an institutionalized symbolic tool for marginalizing LGBTQ+ individuals and policing normative masculinity. Unlike overt hate speech, which is widely condemned and increasingly regulated, "br0" operates as coded, low-threshold, and socially normalized discrimination. Its casual linguistic form allows users to express prejudice while avoiding accusations of discrimination, rendering it particularly persistent and difficult to govern. This reflects a broader and increasingly important trend in contemporary digital environments: harm is increasingly concealed within seemingly harmless language, making implicit stigma a more urgent challenge than explicit harassment.

Second, this study identifies three interlocking mechanisms that sustain and amplify "br0"-related stigma: identity-based labeling, normative gender policing, and trivialization. Identity labeling reduces LGBTQ+ people to simplified and devalued categories; gender policing reinforces rigid patriarchal ideals of masculinity; and trivialization excuses harm under the cover of entertainment. Together, these mechanisms form a self-reinforcing cycle in which discrimination appears normal, harmless, and socially acceptable. Such a structure explains why subtle digital stigma spreads rapidly and produces cumulative psychological damage, even in the absence of overt violence.

Third, the observed cross-platform variations carry meaningful implications for digital governance. Weibo exhibited the highest trivialization rate, likely due to its highly public character, relative anonymity, and comment-driven interactive culture. Douyin concentrated more heavily on behavioral stigma, reflecting its mainstream audience and emphasis on normative gender performance. Bilibili showed the lowest overall stigma and trivialization rates, which may be attributed to its younger, more subculture-oriented user base and relatively open discourse environment. These differences demonstrate that anti-discrimination interventions cannot follow a one-size-fits-all model; platforms must develop targeted strategies based on their unique user structures and discourse ecologies.

Fourth, the strong positive correlation between "br0" exposure and psychological distress confirms that meme-based stigma is neither abstract nor harmless. For targeted individuals, repeated exposure to devaluing labels can increase anxiety, depression, social avoidance, and negative self-perception. This finding aligns with classic and contemporary stigma theory, which emphasizes that chronic identity-based devaluation poses measurable threats to mental health [5][6]. In this sense, "br0" and similar memes represent a hidden public health concern embedded in everyday online interaction.

Fifth, the ROC analysis yielded strong classification performance (AUC = 0.89), supporting the feasibility of automated detection for implicit and coded stigmatizing content. Most current content moderation systems focus on obvious slurs and explicit hate speech but fail to capture context-dependent, meme-based

discrimination. This study provides a proof of concept that machine learning can effectively identify subtle digital stigma, offering a practical and scalable path for platforms to strengthen governance without excessive reliance on manual review.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The cross-sectional design limits causal interpretations of the relationship between exposure and distress. The sample is restricted to three platforms, and self-reported psychological measures may be subject to subjective bias. Future studies could adopt longitudinal designs, expand platform coverage, and integrate qualitative or ethnographic methods to explore lived experiences of stigma in greater depth.

Overall, this study highlights the importance of recognizing implicit digital stigma as a distinct and urgent social issue. As memes and neologisms continue to shape online culture, societies must move beyond defining discrimination only as explicit hostility. Achieving truly inclusive digital spaces requires improved platform governance, enhanced media literacy, stronger anti-discrimination education, and sustained efforts to challenge rigid gender and sexual stereotypes.

6 Conclusion

This study systematically examines the stigmatizing characteristics, operational mechanisms, cross-platform differences, and psychological impacts of the online meme “br0”. Findings reveal that the vast majority of uses are discriminatory, sustained by three interlocking mechanisms: identity stigma, gender policing, and trivialization. Exposure to “br0” is significantly associated with increased psychological distress, and automated detection of such implicit stigma is both feasible and effective.

These results carry important implications for researchers, platform developers, educators, and policymakers. Coded meme-based discrimination is widespread, normalized, and psychologically harmful, yet it remains largely overlooked in current governance frameworks. To build safer and more inclusive digital environments, stakeholders must enhance detection technologies, reduce the trivialization of harm, promote media literacy, and foster respect for gender and sexual diversity.

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